

CORPORATE VISUAL NOVEL · INTERACTIVE CULTURAL-NEGOTIATION
SIMULATOR

China Deal Simulator

محاكي الصفقات الصينية

Protocols & Business Relationships (Guanxi & Mianzi)

A complete project summary: what was built, how it works,
every level, every choice, and the cultural & design
reasoning behind each one.

Stack	React 18 + Vite (single-page state machine)
Format	Bilingual Arabic (RTL) / Chinese visual novel
Scope	4 levels · 16 core events · 14 recovery branches · 6 endings
Prepared	25 July 2026

1. What This Project Is

China Deal Simulator is a browser-based interactive visual novel that trains a Saudi business negotiator to survive a real Chinese business trip — from the airport dinner to the signed contract — without an on-screen script telling them what to do. The player reads a scene in Arabic (with a Chinese subtitle line underneath, exactly as it would sound through an interpreter), picks one of two or three responses, and watches two live meters — **Guanxi** (关系, relationship capital) and **Mianzi** (面子, face) — move up or down in response.

There is no narrator grading you after the fact. The consequence *is* the story: a mismanaged toast changes the next line of dialogue, a wrong gift changes who is still in the room, and enough bad calls end the meeting outright with the Chinese delegation walking out. Every single choice, successful or not, carries a short analyst's note explaining *why* it landed the way it did — so the "game" doubles as a structured cultural-competency lesson.

4

playable levels

16

core story events

14

recovery branches

~46

distinct choices written

2

live relationship meters

6

possible early endings

2. Why This Project Exists

Saudi-China trade has grown fast enough that a company can lose a deal not on price, but on protocol: seating the wrong person facing the door, correcting an aide in front of her boss, or handing over a watch as a gift. Those mistakes are rarely explained to the foreign side in the room — the Chinese counterpart simply cools, disengages, or ends the meeting, and the Saudi negotiator often never learns exactly what went wrong. Reading a briefing document about "Guanxi" and "Mianzi" in the abstract does not build the reflex to act correctly under real social pressure, at speed, in the room.

This project's answer was to turn the briefing into a rehearsal: put the player in the exact high-stakes moments (the toast, the seating, the gift, the silent negotiating tactic, the mistranslated clause) and let them feel the cost of guessing wrong, immediately, in the fiction, instead of in a real boardroom in Shenzhen. The two-meter system exists so the cost is never abstract — it is a number that moves, in view, the instant a choice is made.

3. Design Pillars — The Reasoning Behind Each Decision

3.1 Two meters instead of one score

A single "reputation" score would blur two very different failure modes. **Guanxi** tracks the health of the long-term relationship — it can dip from a single awkward moment and recover over the course of a scene. **Mianzi** tracks dignity in the room right now — it is far more punishing (a bad gift alone costs 30 points) because losing face in Chinese business culture is a much sharper, less-forgivable event than a relationship wobble. Splitting them lets the simulator teach the real-world distinction: you can survive damaging the relationship a little, but humiliating someone publicly can end the meeting on the spot.

3.2 The "one recovery branch" mechanic

Almost every mistake does not end the game immediately — it drops the player into a *branch* node: a single extra scene to acknowledge and repair the misstep. This mirrors reality: a foreign guest's first mistake is usually met with a polite, face-saving pause rather than instant expulsion — but the second mistake, or an unrepentant reaction to the first, is not forgiven. The branch design teaches the single most important negotiating skill in the whole simulator: *how you recover from an error matters as much as not making it*. Every branch offers exactly one path back to "warning" (partial recovery), one path that repeats the mistake harder (an instant walkout / game over), and one path that is simply inert (silence, avoidance) and quietly costs Guanxi.

3.3 Bilingual, RTL-first presentation

The interface reads right-to-left in Arabic by default (`<html dir="rtl">`), with a Chinese subtitle line under every spoken line and choice. This is not decorative: it reproduces the actual sensory experience of doing business in China through an interpreter — you read your own language, but the room is speaking Chinese, and the Chinese text is always present as a reminder of whose cultural ground you are standing on.

3.4 Four acts that mirror a real trip's chronology

The levels are not arbitrary difficulty tiers; they follow the literal order of a Chinese business delegation's day: the restaurant welcome dinner, the banquet's drinking and toasting rituals, the factory floor inspection, and finally the boardroom negotiation and signing ceremony. Each act tests a different *category* of skill — hierarchy awareness, social-pressure endurance, technical diplomacy, and hard-negotiation tactics — because those are genuinely different skills a negotiator needs across a single visit.

3.5 Every choice ships with its own "why"

Rather than a generic pass/fail, every single choice — including the failing ones — carries a one- or two-sentence cultural analysis (see `choice.analysis` / `choice.gameoverText` in the source). This turns each wrong answer into a teaching moment instead of a dead end, which is the entire pedagogical premise of the simulator: you are meant to replay it and get better, not just "win" once.

4. Technical Architecture

Framework	React 18.3 + Vite 5 (via <code>@vitejs/plugin-react</code>)
State model	A single <code>useState</code> reducer-style state object in <code>App.jsx</code> : <code>{ screen, nodeId, guanxi, mianzi, lastVerdict, log, gameOverText }</code>
Content model	<code>src/Story.js</code> — a plain data object (<code>STORY</code>) mapping node IDs to scene data, entirely decoupled from rendering logic
Screens	<code>start</code> → <code>game</code> (level intro / dialogue) → <code>gameover</code> or <code>evaluation</code>
Fonts	Tajawal (Arabic) + Noto Sans SC (Chinese), loaded from Google Fonts
Assets	<code>public/assets/</code> — character portraits (3 emotion states each), 4 full-scene background paintings

4.1 Why a hand-rolled state machine instead of a routing library or a game engine

The entire narrative is a directed graph of ~30 nodes with simple linear-plus-branch structure; a router or full game engine would add abstraction the content doesn't need. A flat `nodeId` string plus a lookup into the `STORY` object is enough to render any scene, and `choice.next` is the only thing that moves the story forward — the entire "engine" is the ~15-line `handleChoice` function in `App.jsx`.

4.2 Why content lives in `Story.js`, separate from `App.jsx`

Splitting narrative data from render logic means the ~30 scenes, ~90 lines of dialogue, and every cultural-analysis note can be edited, translated, or extended without touching a single React component. `App.jsx` only knows how to draw whatever node is active; it has zero awareness of what happens in Level 3 versus Level 1.

4.3 Asset-mapping conventions

Two small lookup tables in `App.jsx` do all the visual staging automatically from the current node ID, so the story data never has to hardcode an image path:

- `characterImageMap` — maps a speaker's display name (e.g. "السيدة لي") to an asset-file prefix (`Ms.li`), then appends `-Happy` / `-Neutral` / `-Mad` depending on the verdict of the *previous* choice (`success` → Happy, `fail` / `gameover` → Mad).
- `getBackgroundUrl(nodeId)` — switches the full-bleed background by reading the node-ID prefix: `l3*` → factory floor, `l4ev4` → signing hall, `l4*` → boardroom, anything else → restaurant.

5. Core Game Mechanics

5.1 The meters

Starting values	Guanxi = 50, Mianzi = 50 (out of 0-100, clamped)
Guanxi warning	Below 30 → a persistent on-screen "Relationship at risk" banner
Mianzi hard-fail	Below 20 → immediate, automatic game over, regardless of which node the player is on — running out of face ends the meeting no matter what else is happening

5.2 Verdict types and what each one does

SUCCESS	Best-practice answer; largest positive meter swing; always advances the story forward, never opens a recovery branch.
WARNING	An acceptable but imperfect answer, or a successful recovery from an earlier mistake; small positive or neutral swing.
FAIL	A real cultural misstep; meter penalty, and in the more serious cases the story routes to a one-shot recovery <i>branch</i> node before continuing.
GAME OVER	An unrecoverable move, almost always only reachable from inside a recovery branch (i.e. failing to fix a mistake, or reacting badly to being caught) — the simulation ends immediately with a custom walkout line.

5.3 Final evaluation & scoring

Reaching the end of Level 4 without a game-over routes to the **Evaluation screen**, which sums the final Guanxi + Mianzi (max 200) into four bands:

≥ 170	"Excellent performance — negotiator ready for the Chinese market"
≥ 130	"Good performance with a few slips — a solid foundation"
≥ 90	"Average performance — needs to review basic protocols"
< 90	"Weak performance — a re-run and concept review is recommended"

5.4 Event order & endings

The canonical event sequence is `ev1-ev6 → l2ev1-l2ev4 → l3ev1-l3ev4 → l4ev1-l4ev4`, with a full-screen **Level Intro** card (bilingual title, scene description, objective) inserted before Levels 2, 3, and 4. Six distinct scripted walkouts exist across the four levels (one embedded inside a branch of nearly every event), plus the generic Mianzi-exhaustion walkout line, giving the player seven total ways the trip can end badly before the final signature.

6. Visual & UI Design System

The palette is a deliberate "imperial ledger" theme — deep navy background, lacquer red, and gold — chosen to visually cue formality and high stakes rather than a casual game aesthetic.

#060b14
page background

#0d1626
panel / dialogue box

#c7a24a
gold (primary accent)

#8f2536
lacquer red (buttons,
fail)

#4caf7d
success green

- **Dialogue box** — fully opaque panel with a gold top border, so the spoken line is always legible against any background scene.
- **Choice buttons** — translucent, blurred "glassmorphic" cards, deliberately the opposite treatment from the solid dialogue box, so the player's own decisions visually read as "in front of" the fixed scene, not part of it.
- **Character portraits** — swap automatically between Happy / Neutral / Mad artwork based on the verdict of the choice that was just made, giving instant emotional feedback without any extra UI.
- **Backgrounds** — one full-bleed painted scene per act (restaurant, factory, boardroom, signing hall), reinforcing which "act" of the trip the player is in.
- **Typography** — Tajawal for Arabic body text, Noto Sans SC for the Chinese subtitle line beneath it.

7. The Four Levels — Full Walkthrough

Every scene below is given in three layers: the English sense of what happens and why it matters (for reading at a glance), followed by the original Arabic line the player sees and its Chinese subtitle, exactly as shipped in `src/Story.js`.

LEVEL 1 — THE RESTAURANT WELCOME

First Contact & Hierarchy

المرحلة الأولى: الترحيب وبروتوكولات الاستقبال · 第一关：欢迎与接待礼仪

Setting	Restaurant lobby, then a private dining room, on the evening of arrival in Shenzhen.
Cast present	Ms. Li (Vice President, host), Ms. Chen (Li's aide)
Design objective	Establish hierarchy-awareness, correct greeting protocol, seating etiquette, toasting posture, saving a colleague's face, and gift-giving symbolism — the six foundational rituals of a first meeting.

EVENT 1

Greeting & Titles

Restaurant lobby — moment of arrival · Speaker: Ms. Li

Ms. Li steps forward to welcome you in the restaurant lobby.

تتقدم السيدة لي للترحيب بك في بهو المطعم.

李女士走到餐厅大堂，前来迎接你。

“Hello ma'am, very pleased to meet you.”

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi **-10**

مرحبًا سيدتي، أنا سعيد جدًا بلقائك.

你好，李女士，很高兴认识你。

Why: Skipping her full title read as indifference to her standing within the company.

“Hello Vice President Li, it is a great honor to meet you.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi 0

Mianzi **+10**

مرحبًا نائبة الرئيس لي، شرف كبير لي هذا اللقاء.

您好，李副总裁，能与您见面深感荣幸。

Why: Using the full title showed hierarchy-awareness — the bedrock of any Chinese business relationship.

“(You switch to fast, fluent Chinese to impress her)”

FAIL

Guanxi **-5**

Mianzi **-10**

(تبادل الحديث باللغة الصينية بطلاقة تامة وبسرعة لإبهارها)

你主动用流利的中文快速交谈，试图让她印象深刻。

Why: Showing off fluency on first contact read as trying to seize control of the moment instead of respecting the natural pace of getting acquainted.

The Cold Ice

📍 Lobby — sudden silence · Speaker: Narrator

A moment of silence follows your first reply.

صمت يعم الغرفة للحظة بعد ردك الأول.

房间里陷入沉默，你的选项：

“When do we start discussing the supply schedule?”

FAIL

Guanxi **-10**

Mianzi 0

متى نبدأ بمناقشة جدول التوريد؟

我们什么时候开始讨论供货时间表？

Why: Jumping straight into business before trust is built raised tension instead of easing it.

“VP Li, I'd like to congratulate you on your factory's recent expansion...”

SUCCESS

Guanxi **+10**

Mianzi **+15**

نائبة الرئيس لي، أود أن أهنئكم على توسع مصنعكم الأخير...

李副总裁，我想祝贺贵公司最近顺利完成的工厂扩建……

Why: Referencing a genuine, specific achievement broke the ice and showed real interest beyond surface-level flattery.

“The weather in Shenzhen is lovely today...”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

الطقس في شجن رائن اليوم...

深圳今天的天气真不错……

Why: Neutral small talk did no further harm, but it built no real bridge of trust either — the tension remained.

EVENT 2

Seating Arrangement

📍 Private dining room · Speaker: Narrator

Everyone enters the private room; the table is round, and you must choose where to sit.

يدخل الجميع إلى غرفة الطعام الخاصة، وعليك اختيار مكان جلوسك.

你们走进包间，桌子是圆桌，李女士示意你先进去。

“Sit directly facing the door.”

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi **-20**

تجلس في الكرسي المواجه للباب مباشرة.

你直接坐在正对门口的座位上。

Why: That seat is traditionally the host's seat; taking it without thinking was treated as a serious protocol violation.

“A random seat next to Ms. Chen.”

FAIL

Guanxi **-15**

Mianzi 0

كرسي عشوائي بجانب السيدة تشن.

你随意坐在陈女士旁边的座位上。

Why: Sitting down at random without waiting to be guided reads as disregard for hierarchical hosting protocol.

“Stand until Ms. Li sits first, then take the seat assigned to you.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi **+15**

Mianzi **+10**

تقف حتى تجلس السيدة لي أولاً، ثم تجلس حيث يُحدّد لك.

你站着等李女士先入座，然后按照她的安排就座。

Why: Waiting for the host's cue showed respect for the power structure, reassuring Li that you're a trustworthy partner.

Correcting the Situation

Private room — moment of hesitation · Speaker: Narrator

Ms. Li notices your hesitation before sitting in her usual seat. The system gives you one quick chance to recover.

تلاحظ السيدة لي ترددك للحظة قبل الجلوس في مكانها المعتاد. النظام يمنحك فرصة تدارك سريعة.

李女士注意到你在他惯常的座位前犹豫了片刻。系统给你一次快速补救的机会。

"My apologies, I believe this is your seat" (stand immediately, make room)"

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi +10

أعتذر، أعتقد أن هذا مقعدك (تنهض فوراً وتفسح المجال)

抱歉，我想这是您的座位。（你立刻起身让座）

Why: An instant apology and yielding the seat limited the damage, though the initial impression of hesitation still lingered.

"Keep sitting as if nothing happened."

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

الاستمرار بالجلوس وكأن شيئاً لم يحدث

你像什么都没发生一样继续坐着。

Ends the simulation: Ms. Li reads this as an open dismissal of her status as host and withdraws from the meeting immediately.

"Try to laugh it off with a joke."

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi 0

محاولة تبرير الأمر بمزحة

你试图用一个玩笑来搪塞这件事。

Why: Trying to joke the mistake away made the moment more embarrassing instead of handling it with the seriousness it needed.

EVENT 3

The Host's Modesty

📍 Private dining room · Speaker: Ms. Li

"We are a modest company, and perhaps our grasp of Saudi customs regulations isn't up to the required standard."

نحن شركة متواضعة، وربما خبرتنا في فهم اللوائح الجمركية السعودية ليست بالمستوى المطلوب.

李女士说：“我们公司规模还不小，理解沙特海关法规方面的经验可能还不够。”

“Don't worry at all, we'll train your team.”

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi -15

لا تقلقي أبداً، سنقوم بتدريب فريقكم.

别担心，我们会培训你们的团队。

Why: Your direct reassurance made the host look like she needed rescuing in front of her own staff, undermining her position.

“On the contrary, your company is one of the best in the market, and we'll learn from your experience just as much as we help you.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi 0

Mianzi +15

على العكس، شركتكم من الأفضل في السوق، وسنتعلم من خبرتكم بقدر ما نساعدكم.

正相反，贵公司是最优秀的企业之一，我们在帮助你们的同时，也会向你们学习。

Why: The diplomatic reply gave the host face instead of making her look weak in front of her own team.

“True, the regulations are complex, but we're here to help simplify that part.”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

صحيح، اللوائح معقدة، لكننا هنا لتسهيل هذا الجزء.

确实，法规比较复杂，不过我们此行正是为了帮助简化这部分工作。

Why: A realistic answer that did no harm, but it wasted a real chance to deepen the relationship.

EVENT 4

The Tea Toast

📍 Private dining room — toast moment · Speaker: Narrator

Ms. Li raises her teacup for a simple toast. You must decide how you raise yours.

ترفع السيدة لي كوب الشاي لتخب بسيط. عليك أن تقرر كيف ترفع كوبك.

李女士举起茶杯，向你敬茶。

“Your cup higher than hers.”

FAIL

Guanxi **-20**

Mianzi **-10**

كوبك أعلى من كوبها.

你的杯口举得比他的高。

Why: Raising your cup above the host's looked arrogant and ignorant of the table's respect hierarchy.

“Your cup level with hers.”

FAIL

Guanxi **-10**

Mianzi 0

كوبك مساوٍ لكوبها.

你的杯口与他的杯口齐平。

Why: Ignoring the height difference in a tea toast reads as minor carelessness about hierarchy.

“Your cup lower than hers.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi **+20**

Mianzi 0

كوبك أخفض من كوبها.

你的杯口比他的低。

Why: Clinking at a level lower than the host is a subtle detail that separates a novice from a seasoned negotiator.

Drawing Attention

📍 Private dining room · Speaker: Narrator

Li and Chen exchange a quick glance after you raised your cup higher than hers. The system gives you a chance to recover.

تتبادل لي وتشن نظرة سريعة بعد رفعك الكوب أعلى منها. النظام يمنحك فرصة تدارك.

李先生和陈女士交换了一个眼神，因为你把杯子举得比他高。系统给你一个补救的机会。

“Lower the cup immediately with a silent, apologetic smile.”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi **+10**

Mianzi 0

خفض الكأس فوراً بابتسامة اعتذار صامتة

你立刻放低杯子，报以歉意的微笑。

Why: Lowering the cup immediately with an apologetic smile softened the mistake, though the first impression was still affected.

“Ignore it completely.”

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

تجاهل الأمر تماماً

你完全不理睬这件事。

Why: Ignoring the moment entirely kept the situation tense, with no attempt to repair it.

EVENT 5

The Aide's Slip

📍 Private dining room · Speaker: Ms. Chen

Ms. Chen misstates a critical shipping-capacity figure in front of everyone.

السيدة تشن تخطئ بذكر رقم حاسم عن سعة الشحن أمام الجميع.

陈女士在提到关键的运输容量数字时说错了。

“Correct the number publicly.”

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi **-20**

تصحح الرقم علناً.

你当众纠正了这个数字。

Why: Publicly correcting her in front of her boss destroyed Chen's face — a serious cultural misstep.

“Ignore it and give a vague, general answer.”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi **+5** Mianzi 0

تتجاهل وترد بإجابة عامة.

你没有理会，只是给出一个笼统的回答。

Why: Deflecting with a vague answer avoided direct embarrassment, but it gave Chen no clear support either.

“Turn the conversation to Ms. Li, suggesting the figures be reviewed formally at a later time.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi **+5**

Mianzi **+15**

توجه الحديث للسيدة لي لتأجيل مراجعة الأرقام رسمياً.

你把话题转向李先生，建议正式改期审核这些数字。

Why: Deferring the discussion instead of correcting her publicly preserved Chen's trust — and she is the person who will run your project afterward.

Damage Control

Private dining room — after the public correction · Speaker: Narrator

Clear tension fills the room after your public correction. The system gives you one last chance.

تشعر بتوتر واضح في الغرفة بعد تصحيحك العلني. النظام يمنحك فرصة أخيرة.

你当众纠正后，房间里明显感到紧张。系统给你最后一次机会。

"I didn't mean to offend, but contract accuracy matters."

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

لم أقصد الإساءة، لكن دقة العقد مهمة.

我不是有意冒犯，只是合同的准确性很重要。

Ends the simulation: Insisting that accuracy outranks feelings signals to Li that your vision of the partnership doesn't align with hers, and she withdraws from the deal.

"That was on me — I may have been thinking of another project. I apologize."

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi +10

Mianzi 0

أنا من تسرّعت، ربما كنت أفكر بمشروع آخر، أعتذر.

是我太急了，可能想到了另一个项目，非常抱歉。

Why: Taking the blame yourself instead of Chen saved her face in front of her boss, even though the original public correction left a mark.

"Change the subject: "When does the Shenzhen port closure end?""

FAIL

Guanxi -10

Mianzi 0

تجاهل وتغيير الموضوع: متى ينتهي إغلاق ميناء شنجن؟

你转移话题：深圳港口的封港期什么时候结束？

Why: Abruptly changing the subject looked like fleeing the situation rather than handling it with tact.

EVENT 6

The Gift

📍 Private dining room — end of the evening · Speaker: Narrator

It's time to present your memento gift to Ms. Li.

حان وقت تقديم هديتك التذكارية للسيدة لي.

到了赠送纪念礼物的时候。

“A luxury watch wrapped in white paper.”

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi **-30**

ساعة يد فاخرة مغلفة بورق أبيض.

一块用白色包装纸包好的名贵手表。

Why: A watch symbolizes death in Chinese culture, and white wrapping is used for funerals — a severe, doubled-up mistake.

“A box of dates; when politely refused, you apologize and put it back in your bag.”

FAIL

Guanxi **-5**

Mianzi 0

علبة تمر، وعند رفضها بأدب تعتذر وتعيدها لحقيبتك.

一盒椰枣，对方礼貌推辞后，你道歉并把礼物收回包里。

Why: Withdrawing quickly after the first polite refusal made the offer look insincere.

“Dates wrapped in red and gold; when refused, you gently insist, explaining it's a simple memento.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi **+20**

Mianzi 0

تمر مغلف بالأحمر والذهبي، وعند رفضها تصر بلطف وتوضح أنها تذكار بسيط.

用红金色包装的椰枣，对方推辞后你礼貌地坚持相赠，说明这只是一份小小的纪念品。

Why: Choosing dates with the correct wrapping, plus gently insisting after the first refusal, correctly performed a subtle ritual that foreigners often get wrong.

Last Chance

Private dining room · Speaker: Narrator

Li's face freezes for a moment at the sight of the watch. The system gives you one last chance to recover.

يتجمد وجه لي للحظة أمام الساعة. النظام يمنحك فرصة تدارك أخيرة.

李先生的表情因这块手表僵住了片刻。系统给你最后一次补救的机会。

“I can see you're not comfortable with this gift — may I replace it with something more suitable later?”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi +10

أرى أنكم لا تترتاحون لهذه الهدية، هل أستبدلها بشيء أنسب لاحقاً؟

我看得出这份礼物让您不太自在，我可以之后换一份更合适的礼物吗？

Why: Acknowledging the discomfort and offering a replacement softened the negative symbolism, though the impression of the wrong gift remained.

“Insist on presenting it as-is.”

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

الإصرار على تقديمها كما هي

你坚持原样赠送这份礼物。

Ends the simulation: Insisting on giving the watch despite its negative symbolism makes Ms. Li withdraw immediately, viewing it as a deliberate disregard for Chinese culture.

“Silently withdraw the gift without explanation.”

FAIL

Guanxi -10

Mianzi 0

سحب الهدية بصمت دون تفسير

你默默收回礼物，没有做任何解释。

Why: Silently pulling the gift back with no explanation left the moment awkward for both sides, with no attempt to address it.

The Banquet & Baijiu Protocol

المرحلة الثانية: مآدبة العشاء وبناء الروابط · 第二关：宴席与关系构建

Setting

The same private room, after the main dishes have been served and the toasting rounds and friendly talk begin.

Cast present

Ms. Li (Vice President, host), Ms. Chen (Li's aide)

Design objective

Deepen Guanxi and test the negotiator's ability to withstand social pressure — strange food, hard liquor, invasive personal questions, and the ritual fight over the bill — without sacrificing protocol.

EVENT 1

The Strange Delicacy

📍 Private dining room · Speaker: Ms. Li

A luxurious seafood-offal dish in a rich sauce is served, and Ms. Li personally places a portion in your bowl: "Welcome."

يُقدَّم طبق أحشاء بحر فاخر بصلصة غنية، وتضع السيدة "لي" حصة منه مباشرة في صحنك: "ترحباً بك."
服务员端上一道用浓汁烹制的名贵海鲜内脏菜肴，李女士亲自夹了一份放进你的碗里，说：“欢迎你。”

"Eat a small portion out of appreciation, even if you don't like the taste."

SUCCESS

Guanxi **+5**

Mianzi **+15**

你尝了一小口，以表示感谢和尊重，即使口味不合你的喜好。

تتناول جزءاً بسيطاً تعبيراً عن التقدير، حتى لو لم يعجبك الطعم.

Why: Tasting a dish the host personally chose for you showed deep respect for her generosity — the most valuable gesture at a Chinese banquet.

"Thank her politely but leave it untouched, and move to the rice instead."

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi **-10**

你礼貌地道谢，但没有动这道菜，转而吃起了米饭。

تشكرها بلطف، وتتركه في صحنك دون لمسه وتنتقل لأكل الأرز.

Why: Ignoring a dish the host placed in your bowl with her own hand, even with a verbal thank-you, read as an indirect rejection of her generosity.

"In our culture we don't usually eat this kind of dish."

FAIL

Guanxi **-5**

Mianzi **-20**

你礼貌地道歉说：“在我们的文化里，我们通常不吃这类食物。”

في ثقافتنا لا نأكل هذا النوع من الأطباق عادة.

Why: An explicit refusal of a food gift the host served with her own hand is a severe cultural insult, however politely phrased.

The Embarrassment of Refusal

Private dining room · Speaker: Narrator

An awkward silence falls; Ms. Li feels her generosity was met with a cold rebuff. Options to save the moment:

يسود صمت محرج، وتشعر السيدة "لي" بأن كرمها قوبل بمصّد جاف. الخيارات لتدارك الموقف:

尴尬的沉默降临，李先生感到自己的盛情被冷淡地拒绝了。补救选项：

"I mean my stomach is very sensitive today, but I'm truly grateful for your hospitality and these other wonderful dishes."

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi +10

أقصد أن طبيعّة معدتي حساسة جداً اليوم، لكنني ممتن جداً لكرمك ولأطباق الأخرى الرائعة.

我的意思是，我今天肠胃不太舒服，但我真的非常感激您的盛情款待和其他这些精美的菜肴。

Why: Excusing the refusal with a personal reason, plus sincere praise for the hospitality, softened the insult, though the first impression was affected.

"Oh... do you want to know my bank balance too?" (disastrous joke)"

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

"أوه.. هل تريدون معرفة رصيدي البنكي أيضاً؟" (بمزاح كارثي)

哦.....您是不是也想知道我的银行余额？（灾难性的玩笑）

Ends the simulation: Ms. Li responds with total icy silence to this inappropriate joke and decides to end the banquet, judging that the Saudi side lacks the seriousness needed to continue the partnership.

"Go silent and look at your phone."

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi 0

تصمت وتنظر للهاتف.

你沉默不语，低头看手机。

Why: Burying yourself in your phone after an unintended insult piled coldness on coldness, with no attempt at repair.

EVENT 2

The Baijiu Toast (Ganbei)

📍 Private dining room · Speaker: Ms. Li

Ms. Li stands with a cup of strong Chinese baijiu and proposes a hearty "Ganbei" toast to the Saudi-Chinese partnership.

تقف السيدة "لي" حاملة كأسًا من كحول الـ "بايجيو" الصيني القوي وتقترح نخب الشراكة الصينية-السعودية القوي "Ganbei".
李先生站起身，手举一杯烈性白酒，提议为中沙合作伙伴关系干杯。

"Ask your assistant to drink on your behalf, an acceptable protocol substitute."

SUCCESS

Guanxi +10

Mianzi +5

تطلب من مساعدتك أن تشرب نيابة عنك كبديل بروتوكولي مقبول.
你请你的助理代你喝酒，这是礼仪上可以接受的替代方式。

Why: Delegating the drink to your aide is a fully acceptable protocol substitute, preserving your face without refusing the toast.

"Apologize graciously, explain the cultural constraint, and propose raising juice or tea in the same Ganbei spirit."

SUCCESS

Guanxi +15

Mianzi +10

تعتذر بأدب جم وتشرح القيود الثقافية، مع اقتراح رفع كأس عصير أو شاي بنية الـ Ganbei.
你非常有礼貌地道歉并说明文化上的限制，同时提议以果汁或茶代酒，表达同样的“干杯”心意。

Why: Personally explaining the constraint while proposing an alternative in the same toasting spirit showed genuine, sincere engagement — even more so than simply delegating to an aide.

"Accept the cup and pretend to drink, bringing it to your lips without tasting it."

FAIL

Guanxi -10

Mianzi -10

تقبل الكأس وتنتظاهر بالشرب عبر تقريب الكأس من شفطيك دون تذوقه.
你接过酒杯，把杯子靠近嘴唇假装喝了一口，实际上并没有喝。

Why: Faking a drink is an easily-spotted deception in front of hosts who are well-practiced at watching every detail of a toast.

The Untouched Cup

Private dining room · Speaker: Ms. Chen

Ms. Chen notices your cup is still completely full and smiles slyly: "Seems the Saudi representative hasn't really toasted to our partnership yet!"

تلاحظ السيدة "تشن" أن كأسك لا يزال ممتلئاً تماماً وتبتسم بخبيث قائلة: "يبدو أن ممثل الجانب السعودي لم يشرب نخب شراكتنا الحقيقية بعد!"
陈女士注意到你的杯子还是满的，意味深长地笑着说：“看来沙特代表还没有真正为我们的合作干杯呢！”

"My deepest apologies, I'm not used to such strong liquor — may I swap it for water right now to show my sincerity?"

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi **+10**

Mianzi 0

أعتذر بشدة، لم أعتد على هذا المشروب القوي، هل يمكنني استبداله فوراً بالماء لإثبات جديتي؟
非常抱歉，我不太习惯这种烈酒，我可以马上换成水，以表达我的诚意吗？

Why: Honestly admitting you can't handle the liquor and asking for an immediate substitute was the best possible exit from an exposed lie.

"I did drink, the cup was just too full!"

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

我确实喝了，只是杯子太满了！

بلى، شربت، لكن الكأس كان ممتلئاً جداً!

Ends the simulation: Insisting on an obvious lie in front of Chen, who saw the full cup with her own eyes, destroyed trust completely; Ms. Li decides a partner who lies openly at the first banquet cannot be trusted.

"Smile awkwardly and stay silent."

FAIL

Guanxi **-10**

Mianzi 0

你尴尬地笑了笑，沉默不语。

تبتسم بارتباك وتصمت.

Why: An awkward, silent smile with no clarification left doubt hanging over your seriousness about this partnership.

EVENT 3

Personal & Private Questions

Private dining room · Speaker: Ms. Li

After several toasts, Ms. Li suddenly asks, with typical Chinese ice-breaking curiosity: "What's the salary for business developers at your Saudi company? And are you married?"

بعد جولات النخب، تسأل السيدة "لي" فجأة بفضول صيني معتاد لإذابة الجليد: "كم يبلغ راتب مطوري الأعمال في شركتكم بالسعودية؟ وهل أنت متزوج؟"
 几轮敬酒之后，李先生突然以中国人惯常的破冰式好奇问你：“你们沙特公司业务拓展人员的薪水大概是多少？你结婚了吗？”

"Our salaries are very competitive in the market, and my family is very supportive of my work."

SUCCESS

Guanxi +15

Mianzi +5

رواتبنا منافسة جداً في السوق، وعائلتي تدعم عملي كثيراً.

我们的薪资在市场上很有竞争力，我的家人也非常支持我的工作。

Why: A warm, general answer engaged with the social curiosity without revealing sensitive details — the ideal balance in a culture that values ice-breaking questions.

"Those are private matters we don't discuss at work."

FAIL

Guanxi -15

Mianzi 0

هذه أمور خصوصية لا نناقشها في العمل.

这些是私人问题，我们工作场合不会讨论。

Why: A sharp refusal of an ice-breaking question read as personal coldness, threatening the intimate relationship-building the host was after.

"Answer with very precise figures and details to show full transparency."

FAIL

Guanxi -10

Mianzi -5

نُجيب بأرقام وتفاصيل دقيقة جداً لتظهر الشفافية الكاملة.

你给出非常精确的数字和细节，以显示完全的透明。

Why: Over-sharing precise personal details crossed the expected line of tact and looked unprofessional despite good intentions.

Sudden Chill

Private dining room · Speaker: Narrator

A very heavy silence falls, and Ms. Chen feels embarrassed on her boss's behalf. How do you save the moment?

يسود الغرفة صمت ثقيل جداً، وتشعر السيدة "تشن" بالحرج نيابة عن رئيستها. كيف تنقذ الموقف؟

房间里陷入了非常沉重的沉默，陈女士替她的上司感到尴尬。你要如何挽救局面？

"I'm sorry if I sounded blunt, but in our culture we keep personal life fully separate from work — though I'd happily share other hobbies of mine, like pour-over coffee!"

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi +10

Mianzi 0

أعتذر إن بدا أسلوبى جافاً، ولكن في ثقافتنا نهتم بفصل الحياة الشخصية عن العمل تماماً، ولكنني سأكون سعيداً بمشاركتهكم هواياتي الأخرى كصناعة القهوة المقطرة! 如果我刚才的语气显得生硬，我很抱歉，只是在我们的文化中，我们非常注重把私人生活和工作分开。不过我很乐意和您分享我的其他爱好，比如手冲咖啡！

Why: Explaining the bluntness as a cultural difference while offering a warm personal alternative broke the ice that the first refusal had frozen.

"Oh... do you want to know my bank balance too?" (disastrous joke)"

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

"أوه... هل تريدون معرفة رصيدي البنكي أيضاً؟" (بمزاح كارثي)

哦.....您是不是也想知道我的银行余额？（灾难性的玩笑）

Ends the simulation: The sarcastic joke, coming after an already sharp refusal, doubled the insult; Ms. Li decides this shows a total lack of the seriousness required to continue the banquet.

"Go silent and look at your phone."

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi 0

تصمت وتنظر للهاتف.

你沉默不语，低头看手机。

Why: Continued silence after the sharp refusal left a social wound with no attempt at repair.

EVENT 4

The Battle for the Bill (Qiangdan)

📍 Private dining room · Speaker: Narrator

The waiter approaches with the bill at the end of the evening.

يقترب النادل بالفاتورة في نهاية السهرة لتسويتها.

晚宴接近尾声，服务员拿着账单走了过来。

“Immediately snatch the bill and insist, loudly and sincerely, on paying — repeatedly.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi **+20**

Mianzi 0

تبادر فوراً بابتزاع الفاتورة والإصرار الشديد على الدفع لعدة مرات بصوت مسموع وصادق.

你立刻伸手去抢账单，并大声、真诚地坚持要付账，反复几次。

Why: The friendly "fight" over the bill (Qiangdan) is the expected, valued ritual in Chinese culture; your warm insistence showed how seriously you take the partnership.

“Offer to pay once, politely, and when Ms. Li insists, step back with a smile and thanks.”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi **+5**

Mianzi 0

تعرض الدفع مرة واحدة بأدب، وعندما تصر السيدة "لي" على الدفع تنسحب بابتسامة وشكر.

你礼貌地提出付账一次，当李先生坚持要付时，你微笑着表示感谢并让步。

Why: A single polite offer was acceptable, but it lacked the enthusiastic "fight" that the host expects from a serious partner.

“Suggest splitting the bill evenly (going Dutch).”

FAIL

Guanxi **-20**

Mianzi 0

تطلب تقسيم الفاتورة بالتساوي (Go Dutch).

你提议大家平摊账单（AA制）。

Why: Suggesting a split bill at a relationship-building banquet implies the partnership is a cold, purely transactional affair — a serious cultural offense.

Splitting the Bill

Private dining room · Speaker: Narrator

Ms. Li's face changes sharply, and she insists on taking the whole bill herself, while Ms. Chen looks surprised at your suggestion.

يتغير وجه السيدة "لي" بشكل قاطع حاد وتصر على سحب الفاتورة بالكامل لتفعلها بنفسها، بينما تبدو السيدة "تشن" متفاجئة من طلبك.
李先生的脸色变了，他坚决而强硬地要拿走整张账单自付，陈女士也对你的提议感到意外。

"My apologies, I thought this would simplify your company's financial process. It's a great honor to be your guest, and I'll host you in Riyadh next time!"

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi +10

Mianzi 0

أرجو المعذرة، كنت أظن هذا يسهّل الإجراءات المالية لشركتكم، شرف لي كبير وسأكون ضيفاً بكم في المرة القادمة بالرياض!
非常抱歉，我原以为这样能简化贵公司的财务流程。能受到您如此盛情的款待，我深感荣幸，下次我和我的助理一定要在利雅得请你们吃饭！

Why: Apologizing while promising future reciprocal hospitality reframed the mistake as an innocent procedural misunderstanding and preserved the relationship.

"No, our company policy requires splitting!"

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

بل نظام شركتنا يفرض التقسيم!
不，我们公司的制度就是要求分摊账单！

Ends the simulation: Insisting on the "even split" rule after a clear, sharp refusal from the host reads as a deliberate choice to treat the partnership with cold commercialism; Ms. Li withdraws from the banquet.

"Stay silent and let the bill be paid without warm thanks."

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi 0

الصمت وترك الفاتورة تُدفع دون شكر حار.
你沉默地让对方付了账，没有热情地表示感谢。

Why: The absence of warm thanks after the host's insistence on paying wasted the chance to repair the impression left by the split-bill suggestion.

The Factory Tour & Quality Control

المرحلة الثالثة: جولة المصنع وإدارة العيوب · 第三关：工厂参观与质量管理

Setting

A supply-chain production factory floor in the Shenzhen suburbs.

Cast present

Ms. Li (Vice President), Manager Wang (factory manager)

**Design
objective**

Expose real manufacturing defects and protect Saudi quality standards, without wounding the pride of the factory's managers or sacrificing Mianzi and Guanxi in the process.

EVENT 1

Greeting the Factory Manager

📍 Factory entrance · Speaker: Manager Wang

Manager Wang greets you warmly at the factory entrance; Ms. Li (his superior) stands beside him. He steps forward eagerly, hoping to showcase his efforts in front of his boss.

يقابلكم المدير "وانغ" بحفاوة بالغة عند مدخل المصنع، السيدة "لي" (رئيسته العليا) تقف بجانبه. يتقدم مرحباً بحرارة لإبراز جهوده أمام رئيسه.
王经理在工厂门口热情地迎接你们，他的上级李先生就站在旁边。王经理热情地上前问候你，想在上司面前展现自己的努力和成绩。

"Greet Manager Wang very warmly and praise his leadership fully, before greeting Ms. Li."

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi -15

ترحب بالمدير "وانغ" بحرارة شديدة وتبدي إعجابك التام بقيادته قبل تحية السيدة "لي".
你先热情地问候王经理，并表达对他领导能力的高度赞赏，之后才向李先生问好。

Why: Greeting the subordinate before the superior, in front of both, broke the hierarchy and publicly embarrassed Ms. Li.

"Greet Ms. Li first out of respect for her rank, then turn to Manager Wang with a calm, formal smile."

SUCCESS

Guanxi +5

Mianzi +15

توجه التحية للسيدة "لي" أولاً احتراماً لمرتبتها، ثم تلتفت للمدير "وانغ" بابتسامة وتحية رسمية هادئة.
你先向李先生致意，以示对其职位的尊重，然后转向王经理，微笑并以平静而正式的方式问候他。

Why: Respecting the hierarchy in the greeting preserved Ms. Li's standing in front of her subordinate — the foundation of any successful official visit.

"Shake both their hands quickly, then ask to jump straight into the technical tour to save time."

FAIL

Guanxi -10

Mianzi 0

تبادر بمصافحة سريعة للثنين معاً ثم تطلب البدء فوراً بالجانب الفني لرؤية الآلات وتوفير الوقت.
你快速地和两人握手，然后立刻要求开始介绍技术方面的内容，以节省时间。

Why: Rushing to the technical side without any opening pleasantries wasted the chance to build a personal rapport before the inspection began.

Ms. Li's Chill

Factory entrance · Speaker: Narrator

Ms. Li's expression turns cold and distant, and she steps back, letting Ms. Chen take over the discussion in a formal tone. How do you recover?

تلاحظ ملامح وجه السيدة "لي" تصبح باردة وجافة، وتبدأ بالانسحاب خطوة للخلف تاركة السيدة "تشن" تدير النقاش بنبرة رسمية. كيف تتدارك الموقف؟
你注意到李先生的表情变得冷淡疏离，他开始向后退了一步，让陈女士以正式的语气接管谈话。你要如何补救？

"I mean that it's Ms. Li's wise vision and guidance that made this factory, under Wang's leadership, a model to be emulated."

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi +10

أقصد أن رؤية السيدة لي الحكيمة وتوجيهاتها هي التي جعلت هذا المصنع تحت قيادة وانغ نموذجاً يُحتذى به.
我的意思是，正是李先生英明的远见和指导，才让这座工厂在王经理的带领下成为了行业典范。

Why: Redirecting the credit to the superior while praising her subordinate through her restored the hierarchy tactfully.

"Ma'am, don't you agree that Manager Wang is the real hero here?"

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

سيدتي، ألا توافقين الرأي بأن المدير وانغ هو البطل الحقيقي هنا؟
李先生，您是不是也认为王经理才是这里真正的功臣？

Ends the simulation: Publicly asking Ms. Li to concede her standing to her subordinate repeated the original mistake directly in front of everyone; Li ends the visit immediately.

"Pretend not to notice Ms. Li's chill, and ask Manager Wang to start explaining the machine specs."

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi 0

تتظاهر بعدم ملاحظة برود السيدة "لي" وتطلب من المدير "وانغ" البدء بشرح مواصفات الآلات.
你假装没注意到李先生的冷淡，请王经理开始讲解设备规格。

Why: Ignoring the superior's coldness with no attempt to fix it left the hierarchical wound open for the whole tour.

EVENT 2

Discovering a Production-Line Defect

📍 Packing line · Speaker: Narrator

Touring the packing line, you notice slight moisture in the corner of a trial-shipment carton bound for Riyadh — a defect that could ruin the entire shipment during sea transport.

أثناء تجولك في خط التعبئة، تلاحظ وجود رطوبة خفيفة في زاوية كرتون الشحنة التجريبية المخصصة للرياض، وهو عيب قد يتلف الشحنة بالكامل أثناء النقل البحري. 在参观包装生产线时，你注意到运往利雅得的试运货物纸箱一角有轻微潮湿的痕迹，这是一个可能在海运过程中毁掉整批货物的技术缺陷。

“Point out the moisture immediately to Manager Wang, quietly and calmly, so he fixes it himself in front of his workers.”

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi -15

تشير إلى الرطوبة فوراً للمدير "وانغ" بصوت منخفض وهادئ ليقوم بتعديلها بنفسه أمام عماله. 你立刻低声、平静地把潮湿问题告诉王经理，让他当着工人的面处理。

Why: Flagging the defect in front of his own workers, even quietly, embarrasses the manager in front of the people he directly manages.

“Pretend not to see it now, and wait for the closed-door end-of-day review meeting to raise it as a "shared inquiry.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi +10

Mianzi +15

تظاهر بعدم رؤيتها الآن، وتنتظر حتى اجتماع التقييم المغلق في نهاية اليوم لطرحها كـ "استفسار مشترك". 你假装现在没有看到，等到当天结束时的闭门评估会议上，把它作为一个“共同的技术问题”提出来。

Why: Deferring the observation to a closed meeting and framing it as a shared issue protected quality standards without publicly embarrassing anyone.

“Pull Ms. Li aside privately to have her direct Manager Wang herself.”

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi -15

تأخذ السيدة "لي" جانباً وتخبرها سرا لتوجه هي قرارها للمدير "وانغ" مباشرة. 你把李先生拉到一边，私下告诉他，让他自己直接向王经理下达指示。

Why: Bypassing the manager by going straight to his boss, instead of waiting for the proper formal channel, implies you don't trust him.

Manager Wang's Defense

📍 Packing line · Speaker: Manager Wang

Wang gets defensive and raises his voice: "That's totally normal because of Shenzhen's weather today, it doesn't affect our world-class product quality at all!"

يتحمّس المدير "وانغ" ويبدأ بالدفاع بصوت مرتفع: "هذا أمر طبيعي جداً بسبب طقس شنجن اليوم، ولا يؤثر إطلاقاً على جودة منتجاتنا العالمية!"
王经理情绪激动，提高嗓音为自己辩护：“这只是因为深圳今天的天气而已，完全不会影响我们全球品质的产品！”

"My deep apologies, perhaps this lovely Shenzhen weather threw off my technical judgment. I fully trust your standards, and we can discuss it flexibly later in the closed meeting."

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi +10

أعتذر بشدة، ربما خانتني خبرتي الفنية في طقس شنجن الرائع، أنا واثق تماماً بمعاييركم وسناقش بمرونة في الاجتماع المغلق لاحقاً.
非常抱歉，可能是深圳这么好的天气让我的专业判断出了差错，我完全相信你们的标准，我们可以稍后在闭门会议上灵活地再讨论。

Why: Publicly ceding your technical expertise while deferring the discussion to a closed meeting calmed his anger without abandoning the observation itself.

"It absolutely does! Moisture will rot the cardboard at sea, and the current box design doesn't meet spec!"

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

بل يؤثر! الرطوبة ستعفن الكرتون في البحر، وتصميم الكرتون الحالي غير مطابق للمواصفات!
当然会影响！潮湿会让货物在海上运输过程中发霉，而且目前的纸箱设计根本不符合规格！

Ends the simulation: A direct, sharp confrontation in front of Manager Wang's own workers completely destroyed his face in front of the people he manages; Ms. Li intervenes to end the visit and protect her manager's dignity.

"Go silent and give Ms. Li a pleading look to intervene and settle it." **FAIL** Guanxi -5

Mianzi 0

تصمت وتنتظر للسيدة "لي" بنظرة استنجد لتتدخل وتحسم الأمر.
你沉默不语，用求助的眼神看向李先生，希望他出面解决。

Why: Relying entirely on Ms. Li to intervene, without taking any clear stance yourself, weakened your image as an independent negotiator.

EVENT 3

The Cost-Cutting Material Trap

📍 Materials inspection area · Speaker: Manager Wang

During material inspection, Wang offers an alternative local packaging material: "This will save your Saudi company 12% on total costs, it's well-tested and excellent." You know it may not survive summer heat in Riyadh warehouses.

أثناء فحص المواد، يعرض عليك المدير "وانغ" مادة تغليف بديلة محلية ويقول: "هذه المادة ستوفر لشركتكم 12% من التكاليف الإجمالية السعودية، وهي مجرّبة بكثرة وممتازة." أنت تعلم أن هذه المادة قد لا تصمد أمام حرارة الصيف في مستودعات الرياض.

在检查材料时，王经理向你推荐一种本地替代包装材料，他说：“这种材料能为贵沙特公司节省12%的总成本，而且经过大量验证，效果非常好。”而你知道这种材料可能无法承受利雅得仓库夏季的高温。

"Our standards are very strict, we can't risk cheap materials."

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi -15

معايرنا صارمة جداً، ولا يمكننا المخاطرة بالمواد الرخيصة.

我们的标准非常严格，不能冒险使用廉价材料。

Why: A blunt refusal with no diplomatic lead-in implicitly labeled his cost-saving initiative "cheap" — an unintended provocation.

"Agree immediately, to show commercial flexibility and appreciation for his effort to save your company money."

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi -20

توافق فوراً لتظهر مرونة تجارية وتقديرك لرغبته في توفير المال لشركتكم.

你立刻同意，以表现出商业上的灵活性，以及对他为你们省钱的用心的认可。

Why: Immediately agreeing to an unverified material sacrificed the Saudi quality standards that are the core of your mission, even though it pleased the manager temporarily.

"Thank him warmly for his smart cost-saving initiative, and ask that a technical sample be sent to the Saudi lab for official testing before it's adopted."

SUCCESS

Guanxi +15

Mianzi +10

تشكره بحرارة على مبادرته الاقتصادية الذكية، وتطلب إرسال عينة فنية من هذه المادة للمختبر السعودي لفحصها رسمياً للتأكد من مطابقتها قبل اعتمادها.

你热情地感谢他这个聪明的省钱建议，并要求将该材料的技术样品送往沙特实验室做正式检测，确认合格后再采用。

Why: Praising his initiative while requiring a formal technical test balanced preserving his face with protecting real quality standards.

The Provocation of Refusal

Materials inspection area · Speaker: Manager Wang

Wang's face hardens: "Our factory exports to Europe and America, no one has ever called our materials 'cheap' before!" How do you save the moment?

يتجهم وجه المدير "وانغ" ويقول ببرود: "مصنعنا يُصدّر لأوروبا وأمريكا، ولم يصف أحد موادنا بالرخيصة من قبل!" كيف تنقذ الموقف؟
王经理面色一沉，冷冷地说：“我们工厂的产品出口到欧美，从来没有人说我们的材料‘廉价’！”你要如何挽救局面？

“My apologies, my Chinese expression may have failed me — I meant that our customs standards are especially strict for this specific technical category, and your company is a source of quality pride for us.”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi +10

أعتذر، خانني التعبير باللغة الصينية، قصدت أن معايير الجمارك لدينا متشددة جداً تجاه هذه الفئة الفنية تحديداً، وشركتكم هي فخر الجودة بالنسبة لنا.
抱歉，可能是我中文表达不够准确，我的意思是我们的海关标准对这一类技术材料要求特别严格，而贵公司在我们心中一直是品质的骄傲。

Why: Blaming a language barrier while sincerely praising his reputation repaired the situation without conceding on quality standards.

“But the difference between our specs and European specs is clear on this item.”

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

لكن الفارق بين مواصفائنا ومواصفات أوروبا واضح في هذا البند.
但在这一项上，我们的标准和欧洲标准之间的差异是很明显的。

Ends the simulation: Insisting on the direct comparison after an obvious provocation doubled down on insulting his factory's international reputation; Ms. Li ends the tour immediately.

“Stay silent and ask your assistant to review the technical catalog, to change the subject.”

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi 0

تصمت وتطلب من مساعدك مراجعة الكتالوج الفني لتغيير الموضوع.
你沉默不语，让你的助理翻看技术目录，借此转移话题。

Why: Silently changing the subject, with no apology, left the original provocation unaddressed.

EVENT 4

The Safety Helmet Dilemma (The Unwritten Protocol)

📍 Heavy machinery section entrance · Speaker: Narrator

At the heavy-machinery section entrance, a huge sign requires safety helmets and goggles, but Ms. Li and Manager Wang simply walk in wearing their formal clothes without any gear, gesturing for you to hurry and follow.

عند مدخل قسم الآلات الثقيلة، تلاحظ لوحة ضخمة تفرض ارتداء خوذة السلامة والنظارات الواقية، لكن السيدة "لي" والمدير "وانغ" يدخلان ببساطة بملابسهما الرسمية دون ارتداء أي شيء، مشيرين لك باللحاق بهما بسرعة.

在重型机械区入口，你注意到一块巨大的标牌，要求佩戴安全头盔和护目镜，但李先生和王经理却直接穿着正装走了进去，什么都没戴，还示意你快点跟上。

"Stop and insist on wearing safety gear, asking them to wear it too."

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi -15

تتوقف وتصر على ارتداء أدوات السلامة وتطلب منهما ارتداها التزاماً بسلامة الجميع.

你停下脚步，坚持要佩戴安全设备，并要求他们二位也一并佩戴，以确保大家的安全。

Why: Publicly demanding both superiors follow a rule they themselves ignored, in front of their staff, put them in direct embarrassment.

"Follow them in without any safety gear, to show total adaptation and trust."

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi -15

تدخل خلفهما مباشرة دون ارتداء أي أداة سلامة لتظهر تكيفك التام وثقتك المطلقة.

你直接跟在他们身后进去，不佩戴任何安全装备，以表现出你完全的适应和对他们工厂环境的十足信任。

Why: Ignoring genuine safety rules under the guise of "accommodating the host" abandoned your personal responsibility in the face of a real hazard.

"The strict systems your factories are built on are exactly what we should always learn from in detail." (and you politely put on your helmet)"

SUCCESS

Guanxi +15

Mianzi +10

"الأنظمة الصارمة التي تُبنى عليها مصانعكم تجعلنا نتعلم منكم بالتفاصيل دائماً." (وترتدي خوذةك بلطف)

贵厂能建立在如此严格的制度之下，正是我们要向你们学习的对细节的坚持。（你礼貌地拿起自己的头盔戴上）

Why: Personally committing to safety while framing it as praise for their factory's discipline achieved the goal without embarrassing anyone.

The Embarrassment of Advice

Heavy machinery section entrance · Speaker: Narrator

Ms. Li stops, embarrassed and displeased in front of the workers and her aides, because you stood there advising her. How do you defuse the embarrassment?

تتوقف السيدة "لي" محرجة وممتعضة أمام العمال ومساعدتها بسبب وقوفك وتوجيهك النصيحة لها. كيف تتدارك الإحراج؟
李先生因为你当众站出来给他提建议，在助手和工人面前显得尴尬又不悦，停下了脚步。你要如何化解这份尴尬？

"I care deeply about the safety of talented managers like you, because this project cannot succeed without your exceptional leadership."

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi +10

أنا حريص جداً على سلامة المديرين الموهوبين أمثالكم، فالمشروع لا يمكن أن ينجح بدون قيادتكم الفذة.
我非常关心像您这样有才华的领导者的安全，因为没有你们卓越的领导，这个项目是不可能成功的。

Why: Framing the demand as personal concern for her leadership importance turned an embarrassing piece of advice into an acceptable compliment.

"Rules are rules, we must apply them or we'll be liable."

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

القوانين قوانين، ويجب أن نطبقها وإلا سنكون عرضة للمساءلة.
规定就是规定，我们必须遵守，否则会承担责任。

Ends the simulation: Insisting on strictly enforcing the rule in the face of a clear refusal from the superior repeated the original insult even more clearly; Ms. Li ends the visit.

"Retract your words awkwardly, put on the helmet, and walk behind them in silence."

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi 0

تسحب كلامك بارتباك وترتدي الخوذة وتمشي خلفهم بصمت.
你尴尬地收回自己的话，戴上头盔，默默跟在他们身后。

Why: Retreating silently with no explanation left the moment awkward for both sides, even though it ended the direct confrontation.

The Boardroom Tug of War & The Final Pen

المرحلة الرابعة: طاولة الحسم وحفل التوقيع · 第四关：谈判桌上的较量与签约仪式

Setting

The main formal boardroom at company HQ in Shenzhen, followed by the signing platform.

Cast present

Ms. Li (Vice President), Ms. Chen (Li's aide), the legal interpreter

**Design
objective**

Lead the tough financial negotiation, decode veiled Chinese phrasing, and sign the contract on the best possible terms without damaging Guanxi or destroying Mianzi at the very last moment.

EVENT 1

The Long Chinese Silence Tactic

📌 Formal boardroom · Speaker: Narrator

After presenting the final proposed price sheet, a complete, unbroken silence fills the room for two full minutes. Ms. Li and Ms. Chen exchange unreadable, silent glances — no expression, not a word.

بعد تقديم جدول الأسعار النهائي المقترح، يعم صمت تام ومطبّق في الغرفة لمدة دقيقتين كاملتين. تتبادل السيدة "لي" والسيدة "تشن" نظرات صامتة غامضة دون إبداء أي تعبير أو النطق بكلمة واحدة.

在你提交最终建议价格表之后，房间里陷入了长达整整两分钟的彻底沉默。李先生和陈女士只是默默地交换着难以捉摸的眼神，没有任何表情，也没有说一个字。

“Rush to break the heavy silence by offering a flexible concession, like a special 5% promotional discount.”

FAIL

Guanxi -15

Mianzi 0

تسارع لكسر هذا الصمت الثقيل بتقديم تنازل مرّن مثل تخفيض ترويجي خاص بنسبة 5%.

你急于打破这份沉重的沉默，主动提出一个让步，比如5%的促销折扣。

Why: Being the first to break the silence with a free concession exposed the weakness of your negotiating position before the other side even spoke.

“Keep your composure and calm smile, and stay completely silent, however long it takes, waiting for their response first.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi +20

Mianzi 0

تحافظ على رباطة جأشك وابتسامتك الهادئة وتصمت تماماً، مهما طال الأمر، متمسكاً بانتظار ردّها أولاً.

你保持从容和微笑，完全沉默，无论多久都耐心等待对方先开口。

Why: Withstanding the classic Chinese silence tactic without flinching proved your negotiating experience and fully protected your position.

“Start immediately re-explaining the offer and its benefits, assuming there's a misunderstanding.”

FAIL

Guanxi -10

Mianzi 0

تبدأ فوراً في إعادة شرح العرض ومزاياه مجدداً، ظناً منك أن هناك سوء فهم.

你以为是出现了误解，立刻开始重新详细讲解这份方案及其优势。

Why: Needlessly over-explaining misread the silence as confusion and betrayed a nervousness that weakened your negotiating position.

More Pressure

Formal boardroom · Speaker: Ms. Li

You notice a flash of satisfaction in Ms. Chen's eyes as she immediately records the discount, while Ms. Li says coldly: "The discount is good, but we're hoping for more flexibility to match the future scale of our partnership." How do you stop the situation from being drained further?

تلاحظ بريقاً من الرضا في عيني السيدة "تشن" التي تسجل الخصم فوراً، بينما تقول السيدة "لي" ببرود: "الخصم جيد، ولكننا نطمح لمرونة أكبر تناسب حجم شراكتنا مستقبلاً. كيف تمنع الموقف من مزيد من الاستنزاف؟

你注意到陈女士眼中闪过一丝满意，立刻把折扣记录了下来，而李先生却冷冷地说：“折扣不错，但我们希望未来的合作规模能有更大的灵活空间。”你要如何阻止对方进一步施压？

“This discount is conditional on your commitment to the fast supply schedule only — it's the maximum flexibility our company can offer to guarantee premium material quality.”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi +10

Mianzi 0

هذا الخصم مشروط بالتزامكم بجدول التوريد السريع فقط، وهو أقصى مرونة يمكن لشركتنا تقديمها لضمان جودة المواد الفائقة.

这个折扣的前提是贵公司必须严格遵守快速供货时间表，这已经是我们公司为保证顶级材料品质所能提供的最大让步了。

Why: Turning the free concession into a condition-for-condition trade drew a clear line and stopped further negotiating erosion.

“Alright, what discount would satisfy you so we can sign now?”

FAIL

Guanxi -15

Mianzi 0

حسناً، ما هو الخصم الذي يرضيكم لتوقع الآن؟

好吧，那你们希望多少折扣才能现在签约？

Why: Inviting the other side to name their own number abandoned any negotiating limit and opened the door to unlimited demands.

“My apologies, I need to call headquarters in Riyadh to confirm this discount first.”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi +5

Mianzi 0

أعتذر، يجب أن أتصل بالإدارة بالرياض لتأكيد هذا الخصم أولاً.

抱歉，我需要先给利雅得总部打电话确认这个折扣。

Why: Buying time by referring back to management is a respectable negotiating tactic that prevents a rushed decision under pressure.

EVENT 2

Decoding "We'll Study It Carefully"

📌 Formal boardroom · Speaker: Ms. Chen

When you ask for a formal, written contractual commitment to a compressed shipping schedule that avoids humid seasons, Ms. Chen smiles gently: "This is an excellent proposal, we'll study it carefully and do our best to accommodate it."

(#25105;#20204;#30740;#31350;#30740;#31350;)

عندما تطلب توضيح التزام رسمياً ومكتوباً في العقد بجدول شحن مضغوط لتفادي مواسم الرطوبة، تبسم السيدة "تشن" بلطف وتقول: "هذا المقترح ممتاز، وسوف ندرسه بعناية ونبذل قصارى جهدنا لمواءمته."

当你明确要求在中正式书面承诺一份压缩的发货时间表，以避开潮湿季节时，陈女士微笑着温和地说：“这提议非常好，我们会认真研究研究，并尽最大努力去配合。”

"Thank her and immediately treat this as implicit approval, jumping to the next legal clause without any modification."

FAIL

Guanxi -20

Mianzi 0

تشكرها وتعتبر هذا موافقة ضمنية فوراً للبند القانوني التالي دون تعديل.

你感激地道谢，把这句话当作默许的同意，直接跳到下一条法律条款，不做任何修改。

Why: "We'll study it carefully" is a classic Chinese phrase for a polite refusal or stalling; reading it as approval left the decisive clause without any real, written commitment in the contract.

"Recognizing this phrase usually means stalling or a soft refusal, you politely ask for a specific deadline for their formal response before the signing ceremony."

SUCCESS

Guanxi +20

Mianzi 0

تدرك أن هذه العبارة تعني غالباً المماطلة أو الرفض الناعم، فتطلب بأدب وضع إطار زمني محدد لردهم الرسمي قبل مراسم التوقيع.

你意识到这句话往往意味着拖延或委婉的拒绝，于是礼貌地要求对方在签约仪式前，就此问题给出一个明确的正式回复期限。

Why: Decoding the diplomatic Chinese phrase and converting it into a polite, firm deadline showed high-level negotiating expertise.

"We need a yes or no right now so we can move forward."

FAIL

Guanxi -15

Mianzi 0

نحتاج إلى الآن لا أو نعم لكي نتمكن من المضي قدماً.

我们现在就需要一个'是'或'否'，才能继续推进。

Why: Demanding an immediate, decisive answer clashes with the indirect communication style the Chinese side prefers, and came off as a blunt ultimatum.

Displeasure at the Pressure

Formal boardroom · Speaker: Narrator

Another awkward silence; Ms. Chen stops writing and looks to Ms. Li, who shows clear displeasure at the blunt pressure tactic. How do you save the moment?

يسود صمت محرج مجدداً، وتتوقف السيدة "تشن" عن الكتابة وتنظر في السيدة "لي" التي يظهر عليها الضيق من أسلوب الضغط الجاف. كيف تنقذ الموقف؟
الضيق والقلق يسيطران على السيدة تشن، تتوقف عن الكتابة وتلقي نظرة على السيدة لي، التي تظهر عليها علامات الضغط الجاف. كيف تنقذ الموقف؟
الضيق والقلق يسيطران على السيدة تشن، تتوقف عن الكتابة وتلقي نظرة على السيدة لي، التي تظهر عليها علامات الضغط الجاف. كيف تنقذ الموقف؟

"Please don't misread my enthusiasm — we in Saudi Arabia are genuinely excited to start this historic partnership with you as soon as possible, which is why we care about the logistics details."

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi +10

Mianzi 0

أرجو ألا تفهموا حماسي بشكل خاطئ، فنحن في السعودية متحمسون جداً لبدء هذه الشراكة التاريخية معكم في أقرب وقت، ولذلك نهتم بالتفاصيل اللوجستية.
نحن متحمسون جداً لبدء هذه الشراكة التاريخية معكم في أقرب وقت، ولذلك نهتم بالتفاصيل اللوجستية.
نحن متحمسون جداً لبدء هذه الشراكة التاريخية معكم في أقرب وقت، ولذلك نهتم بالتفاصيل اللوجستية.

Why: Reframing the urgency as sincere enthusiasm for the partnership, rather than commercial pressure, eased the impact of the earlier ultimatum.

"Time is money in our industry, and hesitation might make us look at other options in Vietnam."

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

الوقت هو المال في قطاعنا، والتردد قد يجعلنا نبحث عن خيارات أخرى في فيتنام.
الوقت هو المال في قطاعنا، والتردد قد يجعلنا نبحث عن خيارات أخرى في فيتنام.
الوقت هو المال في قطاعنا، والتردد قد يجعلنا نبحث عن خيارات أخرى في فيتنام.

Ends the simulation: An explicit threat to walk to a regional competitor turned the tension into an irreversible threat; Ms. Li decides to halt the negotiations entirely.

"Silently apologize and withdraw the clause entirely, unconditionally."

FAIL

Guanxi -10

Mianzi 0

تعتذر بصمت وتراجع عن البند كلياً دون قيد.
تعتذر بصمت وتراجع عن البند كلياً دون قيد.
تعتذر بصمت وتراجع عن البند كلياً دون قيد.

Why: Fully withdrawing a decisive clause purely to calm the moment sacrificed your company's real interests for temporary ease.

EVENT 3

The Mistranslated Clause (The Pre-Signing Trap)

📌 Formal boardroom · Speaker: Narrator

Just half an hour before the signing ceremony, reviewing the final contract, you discover the Chinese text of the late-delivery clause grants a more flexible extra grace period than the English text that protects you financially.

قبل مراسم التوقيع بنصف ساعة فقط، تراجع النسخة النهائية من العقد، وتكتشف أن النص المكتوب باللغة الصينية الخاص بالبند الخاص بتأخير التوريد يعطيهم مهلة إضافية مرنة تختلف عن النص الإنجليزي والذي يحميك مالياً.

就在签约仪式前半小时，你重新审阅合同的最终版本，发现关于延迟交货条款的中文文本，给了对方一个比双方约定的、保护你方财务利益的英文文本更宽松、灵活的额外期限。

“Publicly confront Ms. Li and both delegations, accusing the translator of trying to manipulate the contract terms.”

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi -20

تواجه السيدة "لي" ووفد الشركتين علناً وتتهم المترجم بمحاولة التلاعب بنود العقد.

你当着两家公司代表团的面公开质问李先生，并指责翻译人员心存欺骗、企图操纵合同条款。

Why: A public accusation of deceit in front of both delegations completely shattered the trust of this final moment and thoroughly insulted the Chinese side's integrity in front of everyone.

“Overlook the small discrepancy to avoid trouble, delaying the signing ceremony and the official photos.”

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi -20

تتغاضى عن هذا الفارق البسيط تفادياً لإثارة المشاكل وتأجيل حفل التوقيع والتقاط الصور الرسمية المقررة.

你选择对这个小差异视而不见，以避免引发问题、推迟签约仪式和既定的官方合影环节。

Why: Overlooking a real financial discrepancy between the two texts kept the mood calm momentarily but left a dangerous contractual loophole signed under your company's name.

“Request a quick, closed-door technical review with Ms. Chen and the translator, framing it as an "unintentional linguistic ambiguity" that needs precise reconciliation before the ceremony.”

SUCCESS

Guanxi +15

Mianzi +15

تطلب مراجعة فنية سريعة ومغلقة مع السيدة "تشن" والمترجم، وتطرح الملاحظة كـ "لبس لغوي غير مقصود" بحاجة للتحقق من تطابق النصين بدقة قبل المراسم.

你要与陈女士和翻译人员进行一次快速的闭门技术审核，并将此事定性为“翻译中无心的语言误解”，需要在仪式前对两个文本进行精确核对。

Why: A calm, closed-door technical review protected your real financial interest without publicly accusing anyone or sacrificing the ceremony.

Suspending the Signing Ceremony

Formal boardroom · Speaker: Ms. Li

Ms. Li stands, announcing the immediate suspension of the signing ceremony, saying sharply: "Our company's honor doesn't accept accusations of deceit. It seems we were too hasty in choosing our foreign partner."

تقف السيدة "لي" معلنة تعليق حفل التوقيع فوراً وتقول بلهجة حادة: "شرف شركتنا لا يقبل التشكيك والاثهام بالخداع، يبدو أننا تسرعنا في اختيار شريكنا الأجنبي." 李先生站起身，宣布立即暂停签约仪式，语气非常严厉地说：“我们公司的声誉容不得这种质疑和欺诈指控，看来我们在选择这个外国合作伙伴上太草率了。”

"Please accept my sincerest apology, I never meant to offend at all — I meant to express the tension and time pressure before signing. We respect your integrity and long history above all else."

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi 0

Mianzi +15

أرجو قبول اعتذاري الشديد، لم أقصد الإساءة إطلاقاً بل قصدت التعبير عن التوتر وضيق الوقت قبل التوقيع، نحن نحترم نزاهتكم وتاريخكم العريق فوق كل شيء. 请接受我诚挚的道歉，我绝无冒犯之意，只是签约前的紧张和时间紧迫让我表达失当，我们最看重的就是贵方的诚信和悠久的历史。

Why: A sincere, unconditional apology combined with exalting the partner's historic integrity is the only possible way out after an accusation of this magnitude.

"The evidence is clear on paper, and if you're not satisfied with the truth, that's your problem."

GAME OVER

Guanxi 0

Mianzi 0

الأدلة واضحة في الورق، وإذا لم تكن ترمي بالحق فهذه مشكلتك. 证据白纸黑字写得清清楚楚，如果你不接受事实，那是你自己的问题。

Ends the simulation: Refusing to apologize and insisting on blaming the Chinese side after the ceremony was suspended ended the deal permanently; Ms. Li and her delegation leave the room without signing.

"Stay awkwardly silent and try to calm things without a clear apology."

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi -5

تسكت بارتباك وتحاول تهدئة الأمور دون اعتذار واضح منك. 你尴尬地沉默下来，试图缓和气氛，但没有做出明确的道歉。

Why: The absence of a clear apology after such a major public accusation left the rift in trust unrepaired despite the session continuing.

EVENT 4

The Photo Protocol & Holding the Pen (Closing & the Future)

📍 Signing platform · Speaker: Ms. Li

You sit beside Ms. Li before the cameras and delegations, successfully signing the final amended contract. Ms. Li stands and shakes your hand warmly with a full smile, then leans in to quietly ask a personal, unofficial favor: help her nephew get an internship or a business opening in Saudi Arabia's energy sector.

تجلس بجانب السيدة "لي" أمام الكاميرات والوفود، وتوقعان النسخة النهائية المعدلة من العقد بنجاح. تقف السيدة "لي" وتصافحك بحرارة مبتسمة تماماً، ثم تهمس لك بلطف طالبة خدمة شخصية غير رسمية: مساعدة ابن أخيها في الحصول على فرصة تدريبية أو تسهيل تجاري في قطاع الطاقة بالسعودية.

你坐在李先生身旁，面对镜头和双方代表团，成功签署了最终修订版合同。李先生站起身，满面笑容地与你热情握手，随后凑近你，低声提出一个非正式的私人请求：希望能帮他侄子在沙特能源行业找一个实习或商务便利的机会。

"Our company strictly separates business deals from family and personal relationships." (with a dry smile)"

FAIL

Guanxi 0

Mianzi -10

"شركتنا تفصل تماماً بين الصفقات المهنية والعلاقات العائلية والشخصية." (بابتسامة جافة)

我们公司严格区分商业交易和私人家庭关系。(你面带生硬的微笑，立刻拒绝。)

Why: An immediate, dry refusal right after a warm, successful signing moment broke the celebratory mood and cooled the relationship you'd just earned.

"Consider it done! I'll smooth his paperwork and get him fully placed the moment I'm back in Riyadh!"

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi +5

Mianzi -5

اعتبر الأمر منتهي! سأسهل معاملاته وأشغله بالكامل فور عودتي للرياض!

这事包在我身上！我一回利雅得就安排他入职，所有手续都帮他办妥！

Why: An immediate, unconditional promise of employment pleases the host in the moment, but it's a rushed personal commitment carrying real ethical and professional risk.

"I'd be delighted to receive his CV and share it with our partners in the energy sector, and I'll do my best to help him as a dear friend of our new company."

SUCCESS

Guanxi +20

Mianzi +10

يسعدني جداً استقبال سيرته الذاتية ومشاركتها مع شركائنا في قطاع الطاقة، وسأبذل جهدي لمساعدته كصديق عزيز لشركتنا الجديدة.

我很乐意收下他的简历，并转交给我们的能源领域的合作伙伴，作为我们这段新合作情谊中的挚友，我会尽最大努力帮助他。

Why: Helping through a legitimate professional channel, without a corrupt promise or a dry refusal, preserved both the personal warmth and the company's integrity.

Post-Signing Chill

📍 Signing platform · Speaker: Ms. Li

The warmth fades from Ms. Li's eyes; she answers coldly: "I understand, thank you." You notice she's lost interest in extra photos or arranging a farewell dinner. How do you recover?

بتلاشى الحماس في عيني السيدة "لي" وتجيّب ببرود تام: "فهمت، شكراً لك." وتلاحظ تراجعها في رغبتها في التقاط صور إضافية أو ترتيب عشاء وداعي. كيف تتدارك الموقف؟

李先生眼中的热情瞬间消退，冷冷地回答：“我明白了，谢谢你。”你注意到他不再热衷于多拍几张合影，也不打算安排告别晚宴了。你要如何挽救局面？

“What I mean, ma'am, is that out of respect for you, I'll personally handle his file as a special, exceptional case — we won't follow the usual rigid procedures.”

PARTIAL / WARNING

Guanxi +10

Mianzi 0

أقصد يا سيدتي، أنني سأهتم بملفه بنفسي كحالة خاصة واستثنائية تقديراً لك، ولن نتبع الإجراءات التقليدية الجافة.

李先生，我的意思是，出于对您的敬重，我会亲自把这件事当作一个特殊、例外的情况来处理，不会走那些死板的常规程序。

Why: Walking back the initial rigidity and offering personalized, special handling brought back some warmth without an explicit corrupt promise.

“Saudi law prohibits favoritism, I can't break the rules.”

FAIL

Guanxi -10

Mianzi 0

القانون السعودي يمنع الواسطة، ولا يمكنني كسر الأنظمة.

沙特法律禁止走后门，我不能违反规定。

Why: Insisting on the dry legal refusal, after the first refusal had already chilled the relationship, kept the farewell formal and cold.

“Smile and leave the room silently with the delegation.”

FAIL

Guanxi -5

Mianzi 0

تبتسم وتغادر القاعة مع الوفد بصمت.

你微笑着，默默与代表团一同离开会议室。

Why: Leaving silently with no attempt to repair the chill let a successful partnership end on an unnecessarily lukewarm note.

8. Asset & Content Inventory

8.1 Characters

Ms. Li (السيدة لي)	Vice President; the primary host across all four levels. 5 portrait variants (Happy ×2, Mad, Neutral ×2) plus a dedicated toast-pose portrait used only in Event 4 of Level 1.
Ms. Chen (السيدة تشن)	Li's aide; present in the banquet and boardroom levels. 3 portrait variants. <i>(Note: the underlying image files for this character are named with the <code>Mr.chen</code> prefix in <code>public/assets/</code>, while the in-story speaker and dialogue consistently refer to her as "Ms. Chen" / 陈女士 — a naming inconsistency between asset files and story content worth reconciling if the project continues.)</i>
Manager Wang (المدير وانغ)	Factory manager; appears only in Level 3. 3 portrait variants (Happy, Mad, Neutral).

8.2 Backgrounds

restaurant.png	Levels 1 & 2 — the private dining room
factory.png	Level 3 — the factory floor
boardroom.png	Level 4, events 1-3 — the formal meeting room
signing.png	Level 4, event 4 — the signing platform

8.3 Project file structure

China-Deal-Simulator/	
├ index.html	# RTL Arabic HTML shell, Google Fonts (Tajawal, Noto Sans SC)
├ src/	
│ ├── main.jsx	# React root
│ ├── App.jsx	# Screens, state machine, meters, asset-mapping logic
│ ├── App.css	# Design system (colors, dialogue box, choice cards, meters)
│ ├── index.css	# Base resets
│ └ Story.js	# All narrative content: STORY, LEVEL_INTROS, thresholds, order
└ public/assets/	
├── backgrounds/	# restaurant.png, factory.png, boardroom.png, signing.png
└ *.png	# Character portraits (Happy / Neutral / Mad per character)

9. Where This Could Go Next

- A branching-graph visualization of all ~30 nodes, useful for spotting any dead ends before adding new levels.
- Persisting the per-choice `log` that `App.jsx` already builds into a real end-of-run debrief screen (it is currently collected in state but only the numeric score is shown).
- A fifth act (post-signing relationship maintenance) or a "hard mode" where thresholds are tighter.
- Resolving the `Mr.chen` / Ms. Chen asset-naming mismatch noted in section 8.1.